

Words, Tone & Style - Study Guide

A map of how context, connotation, figurative language, tone, and exact word choice work together.

Big idea

Words do more than name things. In RLA reading, you often need to determine what wording means here, what attitude it carries, and why the writer chose it.

The five skills

Skill	Question to ask	Main evidence
Meaning in context	What does this word or phrase mean here?	surrounding sentence and paragraph
Connotation	What feeling or judgment does this word carry?	loaded vs neutral alternatives
Figurative language	What does the nonliteral image mean or do?	comparison plus surrounding action
Tone	What attitude does the writer or speaker convey?	multiple evaluative cues
Impact of word choice	Why this exact word instead of a simpler synonym?	precision, intensity, imagery, emphasis, tone

A single paragraph can test several skills

Example paragraph

The editor called the first draft a "promising skeleton": the main structure was present, but the explanation still needed examples and evidence before publication.

- Meaning in context: promising means showing potential, not guaranteed success.
- Figurative language: skeleton means the basic structure is present but incomplete.
- Tone: the editor sounds constructive and cautiously positive.
- Word choice: skeleton makes the incompleteness more vivid than outline would.

Fast decision tree

1. If the question asks what a word/phrase means, start with context.
2. If it asks what a word suggests, think connotation.
3. If the wording is nonliteral, translate the image into plain language.
4. If it asks how the writer feels, collect tone evidence from more than one cue.
5. If it asks why this word was chosen or what replacement changes, analyze word-choice impact.

Common cross-skill mistakes

- Defining a word correctly but in the wrong sense for the sentence.
- Calling a passage sad because the topic is sad even though the writer sounds neutral.
- Naming a metaphor instead of explaining what it means.
- Treating connotation as if it changes the underlying fact.
- Saying "for emphasis" without naming what is emphasized and how.